of ‘letters’ from young readers on the question of homeland defence. A 17-year-old apprentice toolmaker, Roland Schumacher, wrote: ‘We might just as well save ourselves the trouble of rebuilding and working if we were not prepared to protect and defend our gains in the German Democratic Republic.3 A student at an East German university added: ‘Should the warmongers dare to fall upon our homeland, I will follow the great example of Korean students and fight against the plague. In the ranks of the national armed forces, I will defend our gains and my opportunity to study.’4

As part of the militarisation scheme, Honecker was also commissioned by the Politburo to set up a paramilitary labour structure, based on the model of the Nazi Reich Labour Service (Reichsarbeitsdienst). While the new ‘Dienst für Deutschland’ was mainly developed by the Interior Ministry, Honecker was responsible for a large part of the planning to provide basic military training to teenagers, however, his commitment could not be described as passionate. During the spring and summer of 1952, over 100,000 youths headed to the countryside with little or no preparation for the hardships that awaited them.

Almost immediately, the Dienst für Deutschland developed into an organisational fiasco. Training camps erected on bog land flooded; there were shortages of food and sanitary facilities, and medical care was poor. After just a few weeks, some camps reported a sickness rate of 40 per cent, and furthermore, in addition to stomach and intestinal infections, it was learned sexually transmitted diseases had spread, as the camps were not separated into areas for young men and women, leading to accusations of moral degeneracy. As the complaints increased, a delegation from the Politburo – headed by Ulbricht’s devoted crony Hermann Matern – was sent to inspect the camps but absolved Honecker of responsibility for the fiasco.5 Though the details were damning enough, Ulbricht too – who bore a certain amount of accountability – set about reorganising the Dienst für Deutschland, before finally throwing in the towel in early 1953.

The episode proved a considerable blot on Honecker’s copybook. His embarrassment wasn’t helped that summer when the Politburo finally dealt with the problem of his exotic love life, given Edith Baumann was still resisting divorce. Despite her emotional distress, she reluctantly backed